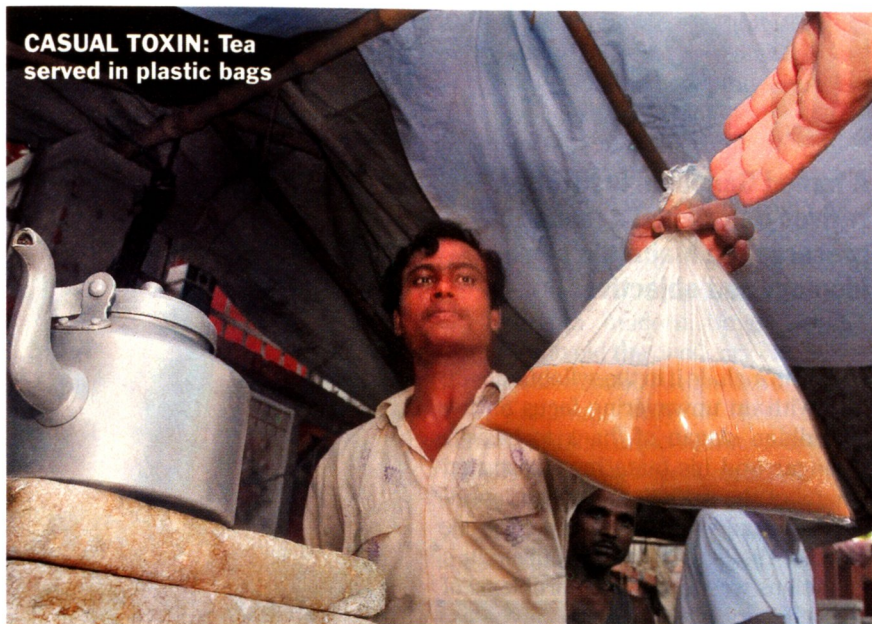




CASUAL TOXIN: Tea served in plastic bags

PLASTIC PLAGUE

■ In 2003, the Uttar Pradesh Government banned the use of plastic bags with thickness of less than 20 micron and a size of less than 20x30 cm. The bags must be colourless and should not be used to carry eatables.

■ Despite the ban, 90 per cent of the total 1,000 tonne plastic bags that the state consumes every month, flout government norms on size and colour.

■ With no equipment to measure thickness, the authorities limit their activities to periodic raids and closure of manufacturing units.

the ban, should his office be authorised to do so. "Barring some perfunctory job of conducting raids and closing down a few units, nothing much has been done," says a senior official of UPPCB. The chief environment officer of UPPCB, G. N. Garg, told INDIA TODAY that it had closed down 45 plastic manufacturing units and served notices on 111 others for violating the board laws.

But Ravi Jain, secretary of the Uttar Pradesh Plastic Association, denies that any of the factories in the state is making illegal plastic bags. He blames the Centre and the state government for adopting a dual policy on plastic materials. "On the one hand, the Government discourages the use of plastic bags and on the other, it allows import of plastic scrap from neighbouring countries," says Jain.

The Lucknow Municipal Corporation has now launched a campaign to remove the piles of plastic from the banks of Gomati to protect the water from contamination. But there is a need for collective and coordinated effort from the pollution control authorities, district administrations and the municipal corporations to tackle the menace. In fact, five years ago, Additional Director-General of

Police Shailja Kant Mishra and senior advocate of Allahabad High Court I.B. Singh carried out an extensive campaign against polyethylene bags. But the law enforcement agencies did not respond at that time.

Jain argues that banning the use of plastic bags is not the solution. "Uttar Pradesh consumes 1,000 tonne of plastic bags every month. If these bags are banned completely, the Government will have to provide paper bags at competitive rates as replacement. That's not feasible," he says. Jain's views are echoed by R. M. Mishra, senior lecturer at the Lucknow-based Central Institute of Plastic Engineering and Technology, one of the premier institutes that produce manpower for the plastic technology.

"The use of plastic has come to such a stage that a ban will not work," he suggests. The Government has banned the use of plastic bags with thickness of less than 20 micron. But 90 per cent of the state's total consumption, especially those used for carrying eatables, are of 5-15 micron thickness. "The Government's law enforcement agencies do not even have the equipment to measure thickness.

So the ban is meaningless," adds Mishra. According to him, the emphasis must be put on proper disposal. Plastic has many good qualities and it's not harmful if recycled properly, he says. "My efforts to draw the attention of the Government towards this have fallen flat," laments Sharma, who also advocates proper disposal of plastic bags instead of a total ban.

The governments of Tamil Nadu, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Delhi and Andhra Pradesh and their municipal corporations and district administrations have made arrangements with local NGOs for proper disposal of garbage—biodegradable and non-biodegradable. Plastic bags are recycled to make raw material for other plastic products. In some states, the recycled plastic bags are used in laying roads. When it comes to disposal, the Uttar Pradesh Government is dependent on rag pickers and destitute children who individually collect the plastic bags and sell them to the plastic product manufacturers. Sharma says he has been writing to the Government to invite tenders for the disposal of garbage in the city. But the authorities have been sitting over the file for nearly two years.

Ridding Uttar Pradesh of its mountains of plastic waste cannot happen quickly. Without a better disposal system and a more educated and aware citizenry, though, it will almost certainly never happen at all. ■



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R. M. MISHRA, SENIOR LECTURER, CENTRAL INSTITUTE OF PLASTIC ENGINEERING AND TECHNOLOGY